Ellie Kuznetsova

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SUMMARY

My research sits at the intersection of bilingualism and natural language processing, with a focus on code-switching and on building language technologies for multilingual communities. Current projects include developing code-switched minimal pairs for evaluating large language models and a sentence-embedding analysis of a Spanish–English tangram corpus. Previously, I contributed to the Writing Feedback Corpus (WFC), a corpus of instructor feedback on student writing.

EDUCATION

University of California San Diego Jun 2025 — Jun 2026
Master of Science: Computational Social Science La Jolla, CA
Capstone Title: *Keyword Search in Tira with Zero-Shot Transfer Learning Model*

Northern Arizona University Aug 2021 — May 2023
Master of Arts: Applied Linguistics and Teaching English as a Second Language Flagstaff, AZ

Pushkin Leningrad State University Sep 2015 — Jul 2019
Bachelor of Arts: Linguistics - Translation and Interpretation Studies Saint Petersburg, Russia
Thesis Title: *Dialect Translation in the Novel "The Plague Dogs" by Richard Adams*

RESEARCH PROJECTS

Code-Switching Grammaticality in Language Models Sep 2025 – Present
Learning, Meaning, and Natural Language Lab UC San Diego

- Lead the full research lifecycle for a Spanish-English code-switched minimal pairs study.
- Develop an end-to-end pipeline for evaluating LLM grammatical knowledge of code-switched minimal pairs.
- Create Python scripts for dataset preprocessing, statistical testing, and visualization of model behavior.
- Compute and analyze surprisal scores using MINICONS to compare model preferences in grammaticality and acceptability judgments.
- Evaluate XLM-RoBERTa and Llama 3 on code-switched data and compare predictions against human judgments.
- Supervise and mentor undergraduate research assistants in sentence generation, quality control, documentation, and data management workflows.

Convention Formation in a Spanish–English Code-Switched Tangrams Corpus Sep 2025 – Present
Bilingualism in Context Lab UC San Diego

- Build end-to-end Python and R pipelines to clean, restructure, and analyze repeated-reference bilingual interaction data.
- Compare word embeddings using multilingual vectors (SBERT, LaBSE, MPNet), cosine similarity, and t-SNE visualizations.
- Implement mixed-effects regression models to quantify convention formation over repeated interactions.
- Fit mixed-effects regression models to quantify convention formation across repeated rounds.
- Analyze utterance reduction and language-choice patterns in authentic game-based interaction.

Keyword Search in Tira with Zero-Shot Transfer Learning Model Sep 2025 – Jun 2026
The Phon Company Lab UC San Diego

- Fine-tune and evaluate a transformer-based ZIPA model for keyword search in unseen low-resource languages.
- Validate audio transcriptions to improve training and evaluation reliability.
- Develop Python pipelines for model training, inference, and evaluation.
- Analyze the performance of the multilingual speech model in low-resource language settings for keyword search.

Higher- and lower-order concerns in instructor comments: Apr 2022 – Present
A corpus-based comparison of screencast feedback and written feedback Northern Arizona University

- Led the end-to-end research process, including study design, project planning, timeline coordination, task delegation, and team leadership.
- Built a Writing Feedback Corpus (WFC), intended for open-access public release.
- Annotated, transcribed, and coded corpus data; reviewed research assistant work for quality control and consistency.
- Authored the introduction, literature review, methods, and references; contributed to the discussion, limitations, and conclusion sections. Manuscript submitted to *Applied Corpus Linguistics*.

The role of feedback modality in student–instructor rapport: Apr 2022 – Present
A study of screencast and written approaches Northern Arizona University

- This study asked whether screencast feedback builds more rapport between instructors and students than written feedback, using independent samples t-tests on the same corpus. The results challenged assumptions about the benefits of screencast feedback.
- Contributed to corpus construction, annotated and coded comments, and wrote the methods and discussion sections. Manuscript submitted to *CALICO Journal*.

EXPERIENCE

Graduate Researcher Sep 2025 — Present
University of California San Diego La Jolla, CA

- Lead a computational linguistics study on Spanish-English code-switching, building a Python pipeline that evaluates XLM-RoBERTa and Llama 3 on grammatical minimal pairs by comparing surprisal scores with human acceptability judgments.
- Analyze bilingual interaction data in R, using SBERT sentence embeddings, cosine similarity, t-SNE, and mixed-effects regression to quantify how conventions form over repeated interactions.
- Fine-tune and evaluate a transformer-based ZIPA speech model for keyword search in unseen low-resource languages, and validate audio transcriptions.
- Supervise and mentor undergraduate research assistants in sentence generation, quality control, and data management.

Graduate Researcher Apr 2022 — Present
Northern Arizona University Flagstaff, AZ

- Co-authoring a chapter on participant recruitment procedures for the LANA-CASE manual, in preparation with Applied Linguistics Press.
- Built the Writing Feedback Corpus (WFC) for open-access release, annotating, transcribing, and coding the data and reviewing research assistants' work for consistency.
- Led study design, project planning, timelines, and task delegation for the research team.

Russian Instructor Jan — Jul 2024
Defense Language Institute Foreign Language Center Monterey, CA

- Taught credit Russian courses at elementary and intermediate levels across reading, listening, speaking, and writing, with weekly lesson plans for six subjects aligned with OPI and DLPT standards.
- Developed 90+ activities with digital tools (Google Slides, Canva, Kahoot, Quizlet, BookWidgets, Smart Board), raising student engagement by 50% and weekly test scores by 30%.
- Administered DLPT exercises and OPI-style speaking tests, and assessed written tests and oral presentations on Russian history.
- Led cultural immersion activities, including cooking sessions and role-playing scenarios.

Translation Intern Sep — Dec 2023
InReach Remote

- Localized LGBTQ+ platform content from English to Russian, expanding language access for 420,000+ users.
- Post-edited 20,000+ machine-translated strings in Crowdin (a CAT tool), improving machine translation and language model output quality.
- Reviewed translations for cultural relevance and terminological consistency.

Writing & ESL Instructor Aug 2021 — May 2023
Northern Arizona University Flagstaff, AZ

- Taught first-year composition and academic writing as instructor of record (120+ students), covering citation, research methods, and writing skills, and tutored 80+ students individually through the University Writing Commons.
- Designed course curriculum and 200+ activities aligned with learning outcomes, delivered through the BBLearn learning management system, and developed English for academic purposes and university-preparation courses in the Program in Intensive English, including courses for 150+ Chinese students.
- Taught ESL, including a TOEFL preparation course (30% score improvement) and tutoring for a hearing-impaired student at Coconino Community College in English, Russian, and ASL.

Freelance Translator Jun 2018 — Sep 2022
Court Translation Services Avesta Commerce LLC Saint Petersburg, Russia

- Translated 50+ legal and personal documents (25,000 words) across English, Russian, and French, in every combination of the three.
- Processed court records and legal materials, including agreements, decrees, appeals, passports, and case files, ensuring legal and cultural accuracy.
- Provided translation and interpretation during 10+ pre-court and post-interrogation informational sessions.

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PUBLICATIONS

Kuznetsova, E. (2025, February). Bilingual sarcasm: Production differences across languages. *San Diego CATESOL Newsletter*, 11(1), 3–11. CATESOL San Diego

Kuznetsova, E., & Wald, M. (2024, June). CIRT-IG report – Corpus corner: Unlock the potential of the LANA-CASE corpus. *CATESOL Newsletter*, 57(2), 34. CATESOL

Chatham, B., Simons, A., & **Kuznetsova, E.** (2024, June). CATESOL San Diego Chapter & 2024 in-person Spring conference: "Foster a community of learners in the classrooms and beyond." *CATESOL Newsletter*, 57(2), 5–6. CATESOL

Kuznetsova, E. (2019, May). Dialect translation in the novel The Plague Dogs by Richard Adams [Undergraduate thesis, Pushkin Leningrad State University]. *University Online Library Biblioclub*. Biblioclub

PRESENTATIONS

Bandopadhyay, O., & **Kuznetsova, E.** (2026, Jun 10). *Keyword search in Tira with zero-shot transfer learning model* [Poster presentation]. Computational Social Science Capstone Presentations, UC San Diego, La Jolla, CA.

Kuznetsova, E., Mittal, S., Su, Y., & Chemotti, M. (2026, June 5). *Seeking truth: Building a classifier to detect fake news* [Poster presentation]. CSS 206 Poster Presentations, UC San Diego, La Jolla, CA.

Kuznetsova, E., & Bandopadhyay, O. (2026, Jun 3). *Multilingual keyword search* [Poster presentation]. Learning, Meaning, and Natural Language lab, UC San Diego, La Jolla, CA.

Kuznetsova, E. (2026, March 2). *Code-switching grammaticality in language models* [Lightning talk]. Linguistics Open House, UC San Diego, La Jolla, CA.

Kuznetsova, E. (2026, February 22). *Tangrams code-switching corpus distinctiveness: Word embeddings in large language models* [Lightning talk]. Transfronterizo Institute Visit to Bilingualism in Context lab, International Mother Language Day, UC San Diego, La Jolla, CA.

Kuznetsova, E. (2025, December 2). *Language teaching careers at the Defense Language Institute* [Guest lecture]. Career Exploration Day in TSL 5371 course, University of South Florida, Tampa, FL.

Kuznetsova, E., Hanks, E., Eckstein, G., Dikilitas, D., Christenson, C., & Matthews, K. (2025, November 14). *Screencast technology in the writing classroom: An analysis of feedback cypes* [Paper presentation]. Sunshine State TESOL Conference, Tampa, FL.

Kuznetsova, E. (2024, October 30). *Russian instructors orientation* [Guest lecture]. Language and Applied Research Center, San Diego State University, San Diego, CA.

Kuznetsova, E. (2024, July 16). *Working at the Defense Language Institute* [Guest lecture]. Language and Applied Research Center, San Diego State University, San Diego, CA.

Kuznetsova, E., Hanks, E., Christenson, C., Dikilitas, D., & Matthews, K. (2023, October 28). *A corpus-based comparison of instructor comments in screencast feedback and written feedback* [Paper presentation]. Symposium on Second Language Writing, Arizona State University, Tempe, AZ.

Eckstein, G., Hanks, E., **Kuznetsova, E.**, & Dikilitas, D. (2023, October 28). *The effect of screencast feedback on quantitative measures of student rapport* [Paper presentation]. Symposium on Second Language Writing, Arizona State University, Tempe, AZ.

Petree, R., Shuvaeva, A., & **Kuznetsova, E.** (2023, February 18). *U.S. education for teachers* [Guest lecture]. EducationUSA Russia, online.

Kuznetsova, E. (2023, January 30). *Culture Kitchen: Russia* [Guest lecture]. Culture Connection AZ, hybrid.

Kuznetsova, E. (2022, April 25). *Masked morphological priming of regular and irregular forms of past tense verbs: Near-native learners' priming effects* [Poster presentation]. ENG 648 Poster Presentations, Northern Arizona University, Flagstaff, AZ.

Kuznetsova, E. (2022, March 5). *Comparing native and non-native speakers' abilities to teach languages* [Paper presentation]. PEAKS Interdisciplinary Conference, Northern Arizona University, Flagstaff, AZ.

Kuznetsova, E. (2017, September 23). *Translation of art books* [Paper presentation]. Translation and Interpretation Studies Department Internship Conference, Pushkin Leningrad State University, Saint Petersburg, Russia.

TEACHING

Russian Instructor — Jan — Jul 2025
Defense Language Institute Foreign Language Center — Monterey, CA

- RU 102: Elementary Russian II
- RU 110: Elementary Russian Conversation
- RU 201: Intermediate Russian I
- RU 210: Intermediate Russian Conversation
- RU 301: Advanced Russian I
- RU 310: Advanced Russian Conversation

Graduate Teaching Assistant — Aug 2021 — May 2023
Northern Arizona University — Flagstaff, AZ

- ENG 105: Critical Reading and Writing in the University Community (instructor of record)
- ENG 205: The Academic Writer's Workshop (instructor of record)
- ENG 405: Writing Commons: Writing, Research, Design, Presentation

- ENG 100: English Composition: Writing Center

ESL Instructor/Curriculum Developer Jun — Aug 2022
Northern Arizona University Flagstaff, AZ

- ENG 85X: Program in Intensive English: Semi-intensive English for Academic Purposes - Level Five
- ENG199: English for university preparedness

ESL Instructor Jan — Apr 2022
Coconino Community College Flagstaff, AZ

- Tutored a hearing-impaired student via the usage of English, Russian, and ASL, focusing on reading and writing as primary modes of instruction.

SERVICE

Professional

- Program and Presenter Coordinator, Conference Committee, CATESOL State Conference, 2026
- Poster Judge, Greater San Diego Science and Engineering Fair, AWIS San Diego, 2026
- Program and Presenter Coordinator, Conference Committee, CATESOL State Conference, 2025
- Post-Production Editor, BlackSea Film Studio
- Webmaster, WIST Conference, AWIS San Diego, 2025
- Local Team Volunteer Leader, TESOL 2025 International Convention & Expo, 2024-25
- Poster Session Coordinator, Conference Committee, CATESOL State Conference, 2024
- Conference Committee, CATESOL San Diego Chapter In-Person Spring Conference, 2024
- Item Review Panelist, WIDA ACCESS for ELLs Listening Test (K–12), Center for Applied Linguistics
- Conference Committee, PEAKS Conference, 2022, 2023
- Volunteer, American Association for Corpus Linguistics Conference, 2022

Institutional

University of California San Diego

- Mentor, Computational Social Science Mentorship Program, 2026 – present
- Co-founder, Europa House, CSI Student Organization, 2025 – present
- Conversation Partner, English-in-Context (EIA) Conversation Program, ISEO, 2025 – present
- Abstract Reviewer (*ad hoc*), California Meeting on Psycholinguistics [8], UC Davis, 2025

Northern Arizona University

- Corpus Coder, LANA Linguistics, 2024
- Manuscript Reviewer (*ad hoc*), Applied Linguistics Press, 2024
- Data Management, LANA Linguistics, 2023-24
- Corpus Recruiter, LANA Linguistics, 2022-24
- Language Teaching Rater, English Department, 2023
- Graduate Student Mentor, English Department, 2022-23

San Diego State University

- Volunteer, Russian Immersion Course, 2024, 2025
- Volunteer, Explore Open House, 2024
- Interviewee, Russian Immersion Course, 2023

AWARDS

Organization Sponsorship, CATESOL Oct 2026
$85 conference registration & $30 membership covered Orange, CA
Rick Sullivan Award, CATESOL Sep 2025
$115 conference registration covered Hayward, CA
Organization Sponsorship, TESOL Mar 2025
$395 conference registration & $690 hotel accommodation covered Long Beach, CA
Computational Social Science Excellence Award, UC San Diego Feb 2025
$16,000 tuition reimbursement La Jolla, CA
AWIS-San Diego Scholarship, UCSD Extended Studies Feb 2025
$1,000 toward course credit La Jolla, CA
Graduate Teaching Assistantship, Northern Arizona University Mar 2022
$11,390 tuition covered & $16,000 stipend Flagstaff, AZ
National Honor Award, Society for Collegiate Leadership & Achievement Feb 2022
Selected for academic achievement Flagstaff, AZ
English Honor Award, Sigma Tau Delta Jan 2022
Recognition of meeting high academic standards Flagstaff, AZ
Graduate Teaching Assistantship, Northern Arizona University Apr 2021
$11,004 tuition covered & $13,500 stipend Flagstaff, AZ

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SKILLS

Programming: Python, R, SQL, LaTeX
NLP: Hugging Face Transformers, LLM evaluation, surprisal analysis, minimal-pair evaluation, prompting, multilingual NLP, sentence embeddings, fastText, keyword spotting, speech models
Models: XLM-RoBERTa, Llama 3, SBERT, LaBSE, MPNet, ZIPA
ML & Statistics: fine-tuning, inference, classification, regression, mixed-effects modeling, t-tests, dimensionality reduction (t-SNE), cross-validation
Libraries: pandas, NumPy, scikit-learn, PyTorch, minicons, sentence-transformers, matplotlib, seaborn, tidyverse, ggplot2, lme4, text2vec, Rtsne
Research Methods: corpus construction, annotation & coding, human judgment data collection, research ethics (CITI)
Tools: Git, GitHub, Jupyter, RStudio, Tableau, Praat, ELAN, Qualtrics, Crowdin
Languages: Russian, English, French, American Sign Language

CERTIFICATIONS

Presenter Certificate, SSTESOL Conference, 2025
Social and Behavioral Research, CITI Program, 2025
Award Certificate, AWIS San Diego & UCSD Extension, 2025
Professional Development Certificate, TESOL, 2025
Professional Development Certificate, CATESOL, 2024
Professional Development Certificate, CATESOL San Diego Chapter, 2024
Russian OPI Certificate, ACTFL, 2023

AFFILIATIONS

Europa House Club, UC San Diego
French Fridays Club, UC San Diego
TESOL International Association (TESOL)
Association for Women in Science (AWIS)
Teachers of English to Speakers of Other Languages in California (CATESOL)
Arizona Teachers of English to Speakers of Other Languages (AZTESOL)
Graduate English Organization, Northern Arizona University
Graduate Student Association of Applied Linguistics, Northern Arizona University
American Sign Language Club, Northern Arizona University
Sigma Tau Delta, Northern Arizona University